TRAINING FOR CESSATION

However, while the research and strategy for cessation have advanced globally, a committee set up by the WHO, the Union ministry of health and family welfare and the Dental Council of India in 2018 found one significant lacuna in cessation support in India—training in modern methods. As per the FSFW, less than a third of the physicians in India receive training in cessation and a third of them are smokers themselves. Indeed, the government app—mTobaccoCessation—registered a quit rate of only seven per cent after six months of use in 2020 as it had only 12,000 formally listed trained personnel. This, despite two million registrations in the first month alone.

"We have now developed a training manual with 18 tobacco cessation experts," says Dr Mohanty. From next month onwards, the national resource centre at MAIDS will run a training programme every four days for a 40-strong batch of dentists in every public dental college in every state. In the end, participants will be tested and awarded a certificate in tobacco cessation. Dental colleges, in turn, will conduct their own training programmes. "We are hoping for a ripple effect so that we have support providers across the nation trained in a modern and scientific understanding of tobacco use and cessation," says Dr Mohanty.

Cessation became all the more important after India banned vaping and e-cigarettes in 2019. "I was doing fine," says 28-year-old Pune student Arjun Seth (*name changed*), "till the ban on vape. Now I have relapsed." Regular cigarettes deliver over 7,000 harmful chemicals besides nicotine. Lower nicotine content vapes or e-cigarettes had become the alternative for many as a means to slowly ease the dependence on higher nicotine cigarettes. But even as NRT remains part of the overall cessation strategy, doctors advise its use only for 1-3 months so that the replacement products themselves do not become a source of addiction. "Medicine and nicotine replacement should be taken under supervision and in a planned manner. These must be supplemented with lifestyle changes," says Dr Chhajed.

WHY CESSATION REMAINS CRUCIAL

Nearly 267 million adults (15 years and above) in India use tobacco, according to GATS India findings in 2016-17. Worse, the age at which people start using tobacco is still worryingly low. The fourth round of the Global Youth Tobacco Survey conducted in 2019 by the International Institute for Population Sciences (IIPS) under MoHFW in 987 schools found that one-fifth of the students aged 13-15 had used tobacco. And that 38 per cent of cigarette, 47 per cent of bidi smokers and 52 per cent of smokeless tobacco users initiated the use before their 10th birthday.

If tobacco addiction starts early, so does the appearance of ill effects. "More and more young people are coming in with lung cancer, heart attacks and bronchitis," says Dr Vivek Anand Padegal, director of pulmonology at Fortis Hospital, Bannerghatta Road, Bengaluru. "Most of them can be connected to the fact that they have been using tobacco for years." According to the WHO, seven per cent of all deaths in India, or around 1.2 million per year, can be attributed to tobacco use. We lose $27.5 billion (Rs 2,197 lakh crore) annually to diseases related to tobacco use. The most common and concerning of these diseases is cancer, with smoke from tobacco now known to cause over 27 per cent of all cancers and 90 per cent of all oral cancers in India. As Dr Shishir Shetty, a medical oncologist at Apollo Hospitals, Navi Mumbai, explains, "Deeper lung smoke over the years can cause changes in cells."

Yet people find it difficult to quit smoking even though they are aware of its consequences. The government for its part has intensified its efforts to discourage smoking and tobacco use. As part of the National Tobacco Control Programme, all tobacco companies are required to use 85 per cent of the space on cigarette packs for pictorial health warnings. Tobacco also falls in the highest 28 per cent slab of GST.

The Covid-19 pandemic was another reason for people to quit smoking as part of an overall desire to improve their quality of life. The FSFW study found that two out of three smokers in India attempted to quit smoking due to health reasons during the lockdown. The WHO predicts that tobacco use in India will fall by 30 per cent by 2025. The MoHFW claims there has already been a reduction of about 8.1 million smokers in the past decade.

But for every person who wants to quit, there is another who falls back into the habit. "This addiction affects their relationship, productivity, self-esteem and physical well-being," says Dr Viswesvaran Balasubramanian, interventional pulmonologist at Yashoda Hospitals in Hyderabad. "The only way they can get out is through trained and quality support." Dr Mohanty agrees. "If we are to bring down the burden of tobacco-induced diseases, we must focus on this huge group that has the willingness but not the means to quit." It's an SOS—and a lifeline—for smokers. ■

> "A lot more people want to stop using tobacco today, but this can only be possible if we provide them **affordable and accessible assistance**"
>
> **– DR ASHISH KUMAR PRAKASH**
> *Specialist, Respiratory Medicine, Medanta – The Medicity*

